My relationship with Moores was acquiring depth and substance. He went above and beyond the call of duty to help me find some consistency in my batting, simulating the pressures of a ninety-over innings by throwing 540 balls at me during a concentrated three-hour training shift at Loughborough. We only took a short break, every thirty overs; I needed to lose myself in the process, forget about being a captain, and concentrate on my batting.

We drilled down into the numbers, which revealed we were winning the majority of sessions in our early matches. We were close to a breakthrough but didn't complete the job. Such niceties meant nothing to the usual suspects, who didn't need to tell me that I would have been out of a job if England had lost that marquee series.

There was, mercifully, a little light relief, in the form of my first Test wicket, which I'd like to think of as the highlight of the drawn Test at Trent Bridge. Ishant Sharma nicked off, was caught down the leg side, and I was away, doing my best Alan Shearer impression. I ran around, pointing at the balcony to remind David Saker, our bowling coach, that I had managed something he never achieved as a proud Australian.

Sakes has a one-word description of my bowling: 'Shite.' But if you have a spare hour, I'll happily go through my eighteen deliveries in Test cricket, as a study of unaccustomed excellence. I average seven as a bowler, which is none too shabby. I took my wicket with a seamer but also served up an over of spin. Imagine if I had taken being an all-rounder seriously …

Garry Sobers, eat your heart out!

I received quite a few texts after taking that wicket, mostly along the lines of 'it's good to see you smiling again'. I was still being hammered but viewed it as another examination of my resilience. I had come close to jacking it in after the Sri Lanka series but as the summer progressed, I acquired a strange, if temporary, serenity.

My stubbornness saved me. I wouldn't allow myself to be worn down. I wouldn't give my more hysterical critics the satisfaction of knowing how deeply I had been hurt. I was being tested as a person and felt a responsibility to those around me. My form was suffering, but it was my job to ignore the noise and lead from the front.

Rod Bransgrove, the Hampshire chairman, intuitively understood the intensity of that inner struggle. I didn't know him that well, but when we had dinner, in the build-up to the third Test at his pride and joy, the Ageas